DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Is the Light Lowered So the World Can Exist?

Daat Tevunot §116-118

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §116-118
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 23 March 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: potential and actual

The class resumed at the bottom of page 256, midway through §116. Having explained how evil came about, the Ramhal now turns to its limits and boundaries. As an introduction, he taught that potential and actual have not always existed. We cannot say God "had the potential" to create the world, because potential implies past, present and future, and change. When God created the world, He created the concept of potential and actual, and everything was first made in potential on day one, and then evolved into actuality.

§116 continued: the plan of existence

The Ramhal now goes deeper. The root of all is that HaKadosh Barukh Hu wanted to bestow His goodness on His creations. So He created illumination, as much as creatures would be able to experience. Since He is the source of all holiness, the natural result would be only holy things, like the malakhim, enjoying His presence.

"This paragraph is the plan for existence," said the Rabbi. It could have stopped there: "billions of malakhim enjoying the Ziv Shekhinah, fantastic, that's it." But then we would not have earned it. If this paragraph were all there was, there would be no need to be born, or to die.

Why did God want this lowly world? So that we would have free choice, and incorporate the good within ourselves because we chose it. For that, the illumination had to be lowered in its ability so that it could produce physical things.

The light clothes itself in darkness

This lowering is a yeridah, a descent. The illumination was meant to be pure holiness, and it is degraded so that the physical world can exist. Whenever we see God giving physical things in this lowly world, it is the result of Him limiting the illumination, which must clothe itself and take on a new existence that is lower than its own. This all happens so that there can be free choice, temptation, reward and punishment, until the end of days when it will be stripped of these dark garments and everything will be holy.

The Rabbi repeated a principle taught many times: nothing in the universe exists without constant illumination from Hashem. "This table is only in existence because there is illumination for it to exist." It is the idea of "hamehadesh bekhol yom tamid", constant renewal. And this constant hashpaah is a lowered one, which allows the physical world to exist.

A participant asked whether this is why we do not see Hashem's hand directly. Yes, said the Rabbi: this is the concealment we have been discussing. But he noted that here the Ramhal is not yet speaking about evil, only about what allows physical existence at all.

How long does the lowering last?

How long is the emanation clothed in darkness? For as long as there is human service and choice, the 6,000 years. When the time of service ends, it will be stripped of its garments and become full hashpaah, and this coarse world as we know it will not remain.

Then the Ramhal says the light rises "elevation after elevation" until it reaches what it should be. A participant linked this to the stages from 6,000 to 10,000 years taught a few weeks earlier, and the Rabbi agreed. With each thousand years, and within each year, the emanation is stripped of more of its covering and becomes more pure and refined, until it reaches what it should have been from the beginning. Hashem did not make it so from the start, because it has to be earned.

Asked whether the physical world continues, the Rabbi said yes: there will be a world and a body, but not the body of today, with needs and urges that pull you to eat and drink.

All of this depends on Yihud Hashem

The Ramhal sums up: God made an emanation whose essence is holiness, and also ways for it to come down in a lower form, and this whole system depends on the revelation of His oneness. The Rabbi explained: how much darkness there is depends on hester and gilui. The more we reveal His oneness, the less concealment is needed, the more the emanations are stripped of their coverings, and the more kedushah there is. "It's all one big system."

§117-118: evil only as much as God wants

The Neshamah responds (§117): this introduction is important for understanding all the preparations needed for this world to exist. It covered two things: potential and actual, and the lowered, clothed emanation that allows the coarse world to exist.

The Sekhel then begins (§118): the bad was created only as much as Hashem wanted. How? Because He is in charge of the knobs, of how much to conceal and how much to allow evil to spread.

He adds that things coming to an end applies only to what is imperfect. Everything physical in this world, even if it lasts many thousands of years, has an end. Spiritual things, the Rabbi added, can last forever, like love. And since the present hashpaah is imperfect, what it creates must end. In the future the emanation will be perfect, and what it produces will not decay, and so it will be eternal.

Can physical things not decay?

A participant objected: surely all physical things decay; how could a physical world not? The Rabbi answered: "You're thinking from the framework of these 6,000 years." Science tells us everything physical decays, because science describes a world made by the imperfect emanation of the 6,000 years. The next emanation will be perfect, so there will be no decay. The first emanation could only produce imperfect things, and therefore it must come to an end, unlike the "new heavens and new earth" of the future, which will not be nullified.

He hoped to finish this topic before Pesah, and noted that with the clocks changing, the class would move to 6.40.

Summary

- God's plan was to bestow goodness, but goodness we earn ourselves requires a lower, physical world with free choice.
- For that, the pure illumination is lowered and clothed in dark garments; this is a yeridah for it.
- Nothing exists without constant illumination, and during the 6,000 years that illumination is lowered.
- How dark it is depends on Yihud Hashem: the more His oneness is revealed, the less concealment is needed.
- §118: evil exists only as much as God allows; whatever the imperfect emanation creates must end, while the perfect emanation of the future will create what is eternal.

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